

Know your regular prices. I once got excited about a shampoo being on sale for \$1, until I reached for it on the shelf and noticed the regular price was 97¢. In this case, the “sale” only meant that the company had paid a premium to be listed in an advertisement, not that there was a good deal to be had. And don’t forget your elementary math lessons when looking at prices. \$4.99 sounds like a great deal when compared to \$5.00, but you are only saving one penny.

Compare unit prices. Check shelf tags below products to reveal the cost per ounce, quart, pound, or per hundred sheets. Bigger isn’t always better, especially when you have a coupon to offset the price. Some couponers love getting free products so much that they will use their coupons that don’t specify a size to get trial-size products free.

Know your store’s official coupon policy. You may even want to go online and print it out, especially when an official policy changes. Cashiers might not be well trained in coupon acceptance and sometimes even a store manager is not aware of recent changes.

Register a separate e-mail address. Registering a separate email address just for your freebie and survey offers ensures that your regular email inbox isn’t inundated with spam.

Write letters. Whether it is a letter of complaint or one of praise, write to companies either through the mail or via email. You can find their addresses on the side or back of the packages. Companies want to know how they are doing and will often send you high-value or even free product coupons in response.